WEEK 8: INFORMATION SOCIETY

Introduction

In information Society, it is stated that information and communications technologies are of increasing importance in many aspects of our lives, and the ability to access and to comprehend information are valuable skills. Particularly the growth of Internet and the World Wide Web is a significant feature of the Information Society.

We now use more information in our day-today life than before. The volume of information available through radio, television, internet, books, newspapers, and magazines has enlarged manifold, both in developed and developing countries. Increased flows of information between parties, individuals as well as organisations, have made interactions information intensive. The way we conduct our personal lives, the way we build and maintain interpersonal relationships, and the way we engage in production and distribution activities have undergone changes that have long-run implications for the society in general and for the economy in particular.

That we can connect to each other almost anywhere in the world instantaneously, can do shopping, banking, our jobs from the comforts of the four walls of our homes, and can have access to the best of entertainment, education, medical care has definitely enhanced the quality of life.

Society is not static. In the language of general systems theory, it is an open system, a dynamic set of interrelated social systems, institutions and individuals that act upon and react to the various aspects of the world around it.

What is Information Society

The term information society has been proposed to refer to the post-industrial society in which information plays a pivotal role.

An information society is also a social and economic structure in which the creation, distribution, use, integration, and manipulation of information is a significant economic, political, and cultural activity. Unlike industrial society, which was powered by steam and electricity to produce physical goods, the Information Society is powered by Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) to produce knowledge and services.

On the other hand, Information Society is a society in which the quality of life, as well as prospects for social change and economic development, depends increasingly upon information and its exploitation. In such a society, living standards, patterns of work and leisure, the education system

and marketplace are all influenced by advances in information and knowledge. This is evidenced by an increasing array of information-intensive products and services, communicated through a wide range of media, many of them are electronic in nature".

An information society is the one that: enables most of' its members to engage in productive pursuits that are knowledge-intensive, knowledge-generating arid knowledge-based. Also, an information society is one that has a communication network that freely circulates information so that this information is consistently, effectively and efficiently acted upon in the making of choices

Evolution of Information Society

The concept of 'Information Society' emerged during the 1970s and throughout the 1980s and rapidly gained popularity and currency, its proponents ranging from scholars and academic authors to popular writers. Prominent among the first group of writers were Masuda, who in the Japanese context, perceived an eventual transition of the society to the point at which the production of information values became the driving force for the development of the society. The second writer belonging to this group was Tom Stonier, who perceived the dawning of a new age for Western Society. He draws explicit parallels and contrasts between industrial and information societies. Although not very comfortable with the term 'Information Society',

Daniel Bell did much to sustain it through his work on post-industrial society. Daniel Bell, the classical exponent of post-industrialism, also theorized the 'Information Society'. In 'The Coming of Post-industrial Society' (1972) Bell argued that the increased part played by science in the productive process, the rise to prominence of professional, scientific and technical groups and the introduction of computer technology, are all evidence of a new axial principle at the core of socio economic system, namely, the centrality of theoretical knowledge.

The emerging social framework of 'Information Society' builds upon this base. Information increasingly becomes a source of added value and thus of wealth. A growing portion of workers is employed in the 'information' sphere. The important factor, enabling discourse to shift from post industrialism to Information Society is the massive growth in the economic significance of Information Technology. Although, in its current form it is something of a novelty, it would be a mistake to think that the idea of Information Society is entirely of recent origin.

Factors determining the arrival of Information Society

1) Shifts from an industrial economy to an Information Economy; that is to say that in industrial economy capital is the strategic resource, while in Information Economy information is the strategic resource.

2) A telecommunication-based information service infrastructure.

3) A high degree of computerization, large volumes of electronic data transmission, data explosion and employment of Information Technology.

4) Characterised by the fact that the rapid and convenient delivery of needed information is the ordinary state of affairs.

5) The growing information consciousness and information dependence of society at large;

6) Accelerating developments in computing and communication technologies.

Key Characteristics of the information Society

According to scholar Frank Webster, the Information Society can be identified through five main lenses: These characteristics explain how a society transitions from being Industrial (focused on manufacturing) to Informational (focused on data and knowledge).

i. Technological Characteristics: The widespread diffusion of digital networks (Internet, 5G, Cloud computing) that allow for instant global communication. The merging of different technologies into one. For example, your smartphone is now your phone, computer, camera, and bank. Technological characteristics is also a move from physical transport networks (roads, rails) to digital networks (fiber optics, satellite) as the primary way society moves.

Also, the wide-ranging innovations in information and communications, from cable and satellite television, personal computers, to internet, since the late 1970s, have been purported to revolutionise our way of life in such a way that it has defined a new social order.

ii. Economic Characteristics: Under economic characteristics, in an information society, information is the most valuable commodity or raw material. Also, a huge portion of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) comes from the information sector (IT services, software development, media, and finance). Similarly, unlike industrial societies where wealth was tied to land or factories, wealth is now tied to intellectual property patents, trademarks, and data. Trading bits (digital data) becomes more profitable than trading atom (physical goods).

iii. **Occupational Characteristics:** A shift in the labor market from manual manufacturing jobs to knowledge work (programmers, analysts, educators, programmers, researchers, designers, and

analysts). High value is placed on university degrees and specialized technical skills. Technology allows work to be decoupled from a specific office location, leading to the gig economy and telecommuting. It is characterised by a shift from blue-collar manual jobs to white-collar jobs. It is not physical effort but ideas, knowledge, skills, talent, and creativity that create wealth in this new economy. It is also characterised by ability to think smart, being innovative, and have the capacity to develop and exploit networks

iv. **Spatial Characteristics:** The information society reshapes how we perceive distance and location. This line of thinking on information society builds around the notion of space, although not completely detached from the economic and social aspects. The concept of space changes; remote work and global trade mean physical location matters less than connectivity. Our daily lives are saturated with media, social networks, and digital symbols, shaping how we perceive reality. It has removed the constraints imposed by time and space. The physical location of an individual has diminished significantly as long as he/she is connected/ subscribed to this worldwide information network. These networks themselves are expanding their reach and capabilities and, as a result, have diminished the constraints of time and distance.

In this era information travels instantly, making the physical distance between two people irrelevant for business or social interaction. There is also a global connectedness of local markets becoming global markets. A small business in a rural village can sell products globally via the internet. Because networks never sleep, the traditional 9-to-5 workday disappears in favor of a constant flow of information and commerce.

v. Cultural Characteristics: Information and media saturate every part of our daily existence. The information society is constantly surrounded by symbols, brands, and media content. Social media, streaming services, and digital advertising are the background noise of our lives. Our identities are increasingly shaped by our digital presence and the information we consume online. Additionally, social media often blurs the line between real-life experiences and filtered or simulated versions of reality.

It is further characterised by access to a wide range of news and analysis, entertainment, personal and community help from across the globe through various media: radio, television, internet, newspapers, and magazines, almost anywhere and anytime, has ushered the coming of a media-laden society. In this new social order, while there is the freedom of choice with regard to a

particular medium, the penetration of some level of information in everyday life has been inevitable. Second, social interactions have become more complex and verbal and written communications have been inadequate to keep up with these complexities. As a result, for example, the symbolic import of dress and the body has dramatically increased. In the agrarian peasant society or even in the industrial society, clothes were just a way of satisfying one basic human need and the uniformity of clothes of the peasants or the industrial workers downplayed any other purpose. The availability of cheap and fashionable clothing and the possibilities of affording it enhanced the usefulness of clothing and make-up as important ways of signaling status, power, and affiliation. Third, the excessive penetration of information has also created problems.

WEEK 9: IMPORTANCE OF LIBRARIES AND INFORMATION IN HUMAN ACTIVITIES. TYPES OF LIBRARIES AND INFORMATION CENTRES.

Libraries are as old as human civilizations. These are important institutions for human and national buildings. Suppose libraries were not important institutions for the last 5000 years; they would have died out long ago.

1. Libraries are places for culture and knowledge preservation. It plays an essential role in society. It creates opportunities for literacy, learning and educations. It shapes the new ideas for a creative and innovative society. It ensures an authentic record of knowledge created by the past generation.

2. Libraries are unique places for educational resources, where people quench their research thirst. It provides 100% safe access to educational resources free of cost. All resources at the library are free without spending money. Those are books, access to the Internet and academic training programmes.

3. Libraries are helpful in local economies. Many people have argued that libraries are not concerned with the economy, but it plays a crucial role in financially strengthening the local economy. It provides free Internet, workspace and material that help the communities to find jobs and similar opportunities. It buys hardware, software and information that help people in finding opportunities.

4. Libraries and information are crucial for human development, empowering individuals with knowledge, fostering literacy, supporting lifelong learning, bridging the digital divide, preserving culture, and driving innovation by providing free, equitable access to resources, technology, and expert guidance for education, research, economic growth, and informed citizenship.

5. They serve as vital community hubs, facilitating personal growth, cultural enrichment social well-being, and democratic participation by ensuring everyone can find, use, and contribute to information.

6. **Education & Literacy:** Provide resources (books, journals, online databases) for formal and self-directed learning, support literacy programs, and teach information literacy (finding, evaluating, using information).

7. Knowledge/Information Access: Offer unbiased, balanced information on diverse subjects, helping people stay informed and make better decisions. Access to information enables people to make informed decisions that can improve their lives. Libraries are seen as vital community hubs,

bringing people together and giving them access to the services and support they need to live better lives.

8. Empowerment: Equip individuals, especially marginalized groups like women and girls, with knowledge of their rights, fostering empowerment and contribution to society.

9. Digital Inclusion: Bridge the digital divide by offering free internet, computers, and technology training, ensuring equal access to digital resources.

10. Community Building: Act as safe, welcoming community centers for gathering, workshops, and cultural activities, fostering social cohesion.

11. Cultural Preservation: Safeguard humanity's literary and cultural heritage for future generations, supporting historical research.

12. Innovation & Research: Provide spaces (makerspaces, labs) and training for researchers and entrepreneurs, fostering innovation and economic development.

13. Critical Thinking: Develop research skills and promote media literacy, helping people navigate complex information landscapes.

14. Libraries change lives for the better. Libraries do not only provide access to books and other literature but also help people to help themselves and improve their opportunities, bring people together, and provide practical support and guidance.

15. **Libraries ensure civic literacy**- Libraries help users to identify, evaluate and utilize information for critical thinking and necessary to make choices essential to one's livelihood.

16. Provide real and virtual spaces where people can gather to solve pressing problems.

17. Libraries can play critical role in kindling civic spirit by providing not only information but also expanded opportunities for dialogue and deliberation as a practice ground for democracy.

18. Provide safe spaces or commons, where people can discus issues and practice deliberative democracy

19. Equal Access: Libraries bridge the digital divide by providing free access to books, the internet, and expensive databases to those who cannot afford them.

20. Safe Spaces: They provide a quiet, neutral environment for study, research, and community networking.

21. Information Literacy: Librarians teach how to find, evaluate, and use information effectively a critical skill in an era of fake news.

22. Community Hubs: Public libraries often host literacy programs, job-seeking workshops, and cultural exhibitions.

Importance of Libraries in Human Activities: Libraries serve as the physical or digital gateways to information. Their importance includes:

i. For Individuals: Lifelong learning, personal growth, career development, informed decision-making, cultural enrichment, and access to technology.

ii. For Society: Supports education systems, promotes informed citizenry, reduces inequality, strengthens democracy, drives economic growth through innovation, and preserves collective memory.

iii. For Development: Crucial for developing nations to build information literacy, improve health, ensure food security, and achieve sustainable growth.

iv. Libraries make communities healthier with their resources, and they are known as centers for curation, health and wellbeing. It also offers internet facilities where people seek health information and services.

v. Libraries are the most significant sources of preserving history and truth. In today's age, information which is available on the Internet is fake and not authentic. Libraries house centuries of learning, history, information and reality and are great defenders of the fight against misinformation.

vi. Libraries connect communities to share their ideas freely under a roof, like town halls, public parks, and other community centers. Libraries are hubs of communities for sharing good thoughts. It brings people of different caste, creeds and races into one place.

vii. Libraries are excellent sources of value to the neighborhood. Those people living near public libraries are great opportunists in enhancing their quality of life. Even public libraries are valuable places for meetings. Libraries are sources of community gathering for social issues and decision making. People of communities come and sit together and share their views.

viii. Libraries break down boundaries and offer free literacy programmes for low-literate and non-English people.

viii. It also provides outreach programmes that teach the community of multicultural and multilingual society. It is an excellent source for home-bound elderly, institutionalized individuals, prisoners, blind and hearing-impaired people.

Importance of Information in Human Activities

Information is often called the fourth factor of production, alongside land, labor, and capital. Its importance spans several dimensions:

i. Decision Making: Accurate information reduces uncertainty. Whether it is a doctor diagnosing a patient or a farmer checking weather patterns, information is the trigger for informed action.

ii. Economic Development: Information drives innovation. Industries rely on data for market research, product development, and global trade.

iii. Education and Literacy: Information is the core of learning. It allows for the accumulation and transfer of knowledge across generations, fostering a literate and skilled workforce.

iv. Social and Political Empowerment: Access to information ensures transparency in government and allows citizens to exercise their democratic rights.

v. Cultural Preservation: Information records the history, traditions, and collective memory of a civilization, preventing cultural amnesia.

TYPES OF LIBRARIES

1. National Library: The national library is the premier library of a country, established and funded by the government. It acts as the central repository for the nation's literature. It is often responsible for collecting and preserving every book, newspaper, and document published within that country. Unlike public libraries, they are primarily for research and preservation rather than general borrowing. **Example:** The British Library in the UK or the Library of Congress in the USA, National Library of Nigeria

2. Academic Library: These are libraries attached to higher educational institutions such as colleges, polytechnics and universities. Their primary role is to support the curriculum and the research needs of students, lecturers, and researchers**.** The library facilitates the growth of knowledge within the academic community

3. Public Library: The public library is based on the democratic principle of being for the people, by the people. It serves the information, education, and recreation needs of the public without discrimination. They play a vital role in local development and the maintenance of a democratic society by providing free access to diverse viewpoints. They often offer community programs, storytelling for kids, and free internet access.

4. Special/Research Library: A special/research library focuses on a specific field of knowledge or serves a particular group of professionals. They are designed to provide specialized information to a limited group of users, such as scientists, doctors, lawyers, or corporate employees. The collection is usually restricted to a specific subject (e.g., a Law Library, a Medical Library, or a Library for a Research Institute). These centers prioritize providing the exact information required by experts quickly to aid in their professional tasks

5. **School Libraries**: School libraries are specialized in learning environments specifically designed for students (Primary and Secondary schools). Often referred to as Media Resource Centres or Learning Resource Centres, they serve as the academic nerve center of the school. The library provides materials (textbooks, maps, charts, and digital media) that directly relate to what is being taught in the classroom. In this library librarians teach younger students how to find information, how to use an index, and how to tell the difference between a fact and an opinion.

TYPES OF INFORMATION CENTRES

Information Centres are specialized institutions that process, analyse, and disseminate specific data to help professionals make decisions. They are often attached to research institutes, government agencies, or large corporations.

1. Archives: Archives are specialized centres that house primary source documents (original records). They preserve the memory of an organization or individual. Unlike libraries, which have many copies of the same book, archives hold unique items. Archives identify, organize, and provide access to non-current records that have long-term value for research or legal evidence

Examples of Information: Birth certificates, historical letters, government meeting minutes, or original photographs.

2. Museums: Museums are information centres where the data is stored in physical objects (artifacts). They communicate information through visual and spatial experiences. An ancient vase or a vintage car is a piece of information about the technology and culture of a specific time. They

collect, safeguard, and research artifacts to educate the public. Modern museums often have their own internal libraries and archives to document the history of their collections

3. Publishing Houses: Publishing houses are producers and distributors of information. They act as the bridge between a creator (author/researcher) and the user (reader). They validate and polish information through the editing process. Publishing houses select, refine, and mass produce information in various formats (books, journals, digital e-books). Publishing houses are crucial for the "Information Explosion," as they control the flow of new knowledge into the public domain.

4. Global and International Information Centres

These centres operate on a worldwide scale to coordinate information related to global health, security, and development.

i. United Nations Information Centres (UNIC): Established by the UN to provide the public with information on the organization's goals and activities (e.g., human rights, peacekeeping, and sustainable development).

ii. International Nuclear Information System (INIS): Operated by the IAEA in Vienna, it provides a comprehensive database on the peaceful uses of nuclear science and technology.

iii. AGRIS (Agricultural Information System): A global system managed by the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) to facilitate the exchange of agricultural research and data between countries.

5. Mission-Oriented and Government Centres

These are set up to support specific national interests or specific industrial missions.

i. DESIDOC (Defence Scientific Information and Documentation Centre): Focuses on providing information related to military technologies, policies, and defense research.

ii. National Informatics Centre (NIC): Provides IT support and digital information systems for government departments (e.g., managing national data on statistics, legislation, and public services).

iii. Patent Information System (PIS): A centre dedicated to storing and retrieving information on patents and inventions for researchers and inventors.

6. Federal Information Centres (FICs): The Federal Ministry of Information and National Orientation operates a network of information centres across all 36 states and the FCT. To bridge

the gap between the government and the grassroots. They disseminate information on government policies, programs, and social campaigns (e.g., health awareness or census data).

Locations: Major cities including Abuja (Radio House), Lagos (Ikoyi), Abeokuta, Port Harcourt, and Kano.

7. Scientific and Technical Information Centres: These are usually the documentation units within specialized research institutes. Examples are

i. NIMR Information Centre (Lagos): The Nigerian Institute of Medical Research in Yaba provides specialized databases and research bulletins for health professionals.

ii. NCAM Library & Information System (Ilorin): The National Centre for Agricultural Mechanization operates as a specialized information hub for agricultural engineering and machinery data in Nigeria.

iii. IITA Library and Documentation Centre (Ibadan): Although an international body, its Ibadan headquarters acts as a massive information hub for tropical agriculture research in West Africa.

8. Regulatory and ICT Information Centres: These centres focus on the digital infrastructure and data standards of the country. Examples are

i. NITDA (National Information Technology Development Agency): Acts as the clearinghouse for all IT projects in Nigeria. It sets the standards for data management and provides frameworks for the country's digital economy.

ii. NAPTIP National Monitoring Centre: A specialized hub for data related to human trafficking. It includes a Call Centre (information intake) and a Forensic Laboratory (information analysis) for legal evidence.

9. Specialized Community Information Centres: These are often NGO-led and focus on providing specific life-improving information to vulnerable groups. Examples are

i. Centre for Citizens with Disabilities (CCD), Lagos: Provides information on disability rights, inclusion policies, and legal support.

ii. American Spaces (found in Abuja, Lagos, Bauchi, etc**.):** These function as digital information centres that provide Nigerians with access to high-end databases, digital literacy training, and information about study opportunities in the US.